

terms as units of measurement, but now it's time to discuss how to use them as elements of a narrative.

Scene

Each game session typically consists of at least two scenes, which are dramatic sequences centered on a particular action or event. Scenes are fairly elastic in definition, with no set time limit or area, but generally speaking a scene resolves a significant action, reveals useful information, or introduces a new problem for the story.

For example, a session revolving around a festival night might begin with a scene where the characters are talking as they get ready for the party, then another scene of them mingling and picking up gossip at the festival, followed by a fight scene as some unruly changelings crash the party. Even though the location didn't change between the second and third scene, the focus of the action certainly shifted, which merits considering them as separate scenes.

When possible, as she is preparing a chapter the Storyteller should try to give each character a chance to shine in at least one scene, or a player may feel superfluous and a bit frustrated. Whether this means letting a character show off his skills and powers or simply making sure each player has a featured role-playing moment at some point, it is nevertheless a helpful goal to make sure everyone gets some attention.

It's also a good idea to vary scene length. Sometimes the action may occur in a series of short, rapid-fire scenes taking no more than a few minutes to resolve, and that's okay. Or a scene may stretch out for an hour if the characters really dive into it and that's fine, too, though really long scenes may need to be broken up by topic or events as described previously. Changing scene pacing and length can help keep a game from feeling stale and predictable.

Chapter

Individual game sessions are referred to as chapters, because it's often useful to think of them like chapters in a book. As a result of the scenes contained in the chapter, the overall story moves forward. Chapters also tend to include one or more dramatic moments where major elements of the story are brought into play in an important way, and either resolved or further developed to continue to play a part in the story.

Sometimes a chapter may tell a short, self-contained tale — a plot that is introduced, explored, and resolved in a single chapter. There's nothing wrong with this sort of chapter every once in a while, especially as a breather between longer story arcs, though using it too often can make a chronicle feel overly episodic and individual chapters a bit disconnected. Used well, though, it can offer some perspective on events that have transpired as well as a chance to size up what might be coming next.

Other chapters may end on cliffhangers — where the session ends in the middle of a suspenseful moment — in order to build tension and build anticipation for the next chapter. For example, the characters might spend a chapter trying to uncover the identity of a villainous mastermind, only to have

Chapter Previews

Without giving away plot specifics or surprises, Storytellers may find it useful to preview what to expect in a given chapter — is it going to be a lot of action/adventure material, with constant fights and chase scenes? Is it likely to be more of a social encounter, with extensive interaction and lots of in-depth roleplaying? Or is it more focused on mysteries and detective work, with players gathering information and uncovering puzzles? Some Storytellers may even do a “teaser” where they describe scenes or images that might come up, in order to build player anticipation.

the villain turn around and be revealed as a character's own mentor... and before she can react, the Storyteller ends the session. Naturally cliffhangers are a great way to keep players eager and excited, but it's important to remember that even chapters that end on a cliffhanger should still have some definite dramatic moments and resolutions of their own, otherwise it might feel like the chapter really didn't accomplish anything except setting up the cliffhanger.

Story

A plotline that requires multiple chapters to resolve is called a story. Many television serial dramas use this model, with long story arcs that build up over the course of several episodes or even an entire season. Each episode still has its own dramatic resolution, of course, but they also cumulatively tell a larger tale that is bigger than any of its individual parts.

A simple three-chapter story structure might go something like this. In the first chapter, a loved one vanishes, prompting the characters to investigate and ultimately discover a Dreamer kidnapping ring. In the second chapter, the characters go undercover and infiltrate the ring, freeing a number of captives and learning the identity of the nefarious noble behind it. In the third chapter, the characters travel to the villain's lair and have the final confrontation, for better or worse. A simple story structure, but no less effective for it.

Many different types of stories and ways to tell them exist, but a few notable variations bear mentioning. The classic Western model is the Hero's Journey, popularized by mythologist Joseph Campbell. It is the story of a humble heroine who comes from unlikely circumstances, rises in power as she risks dangers and confronts villains, and ultimately masters herself to overcome an adversary who has thwarted her numerous times earlier in the story. It's an archetypal structure, and works quite well as the basis for a chronicle so long as the role of the hero is divided among the group and not just lavished on one character while the others serve as comic relief or sidekicks.

Of course, the Hero's Journey is not the only model for chronicle design. Another compelling form is the *Rashomon* story style, which takes its name from a famous Kurosawa film